



The Throne (العرش)
: The Visual Icon of Post-Perception

The Arab-Islamic Philosophical Roots of Post-Perception Art

A Foundational Study on the Indigenous Sources of a Contemporary Art Movement

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Status: Original Research Article – Submitted for Peer Review
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Abstract

- This study investigates the Arab-Islamic philosophical foundations of the "Post-Perception" art movement, a contemporary artistic-philosophical framework that interrogates the fragility of human senses in the age of digital simulation and AI-generated imagery. While much of contemporary art theory privileges Western philosophical sources (Descartes, Kant, Husserl, Merleau-Ponty, Baudrillard), this study argues that the core concepts of Post-Perception—perceptual fragility, the constructed nature of reality, the role of the participant, and the hierarchy of inner faculties—find their primary origins in classical Arab-Islamic philosophy. Drawing on the works of Al-Ghazali (1058–1111), Ibn Sina (980–1037), Ibn al-Haytham (965–1040), Ibn Tufayl (1105–1185), and Ibn Arabi (1165–1240), the study demonstrates how these foundational thinkers articulated theories of perception that predate and, in some respects, surpass their Western counterparts. The study concludes by proposing a methodological framework for integrating these indigenous sources as primary references in contemporary art theory, with Western philosophy serving as a secondary interlocutor for dialogue and comparison.
- **Keywords:** Post-Perception, Arab-Islamic Philosophy, Perceptual Fragility, Al-Ghazali, Ibn Sina, Ibn al-Haytham, Ibn Tufayl, Ibn Arabi, Contemporary Art, Digital Simulation, Cognitive Immunity

1. Introduction

1.1 The Problem of Philosophical Genealogy in Contemporary Art

- Contemporary art theory, particularly in the globalized context of biennales, academic publications, and critical discourse, operates under an implicit philosophical genealogy. This genealogy typically traces its lineage through a Western canon: from Plato's cave to Descartes' methodological doubt, from Kant's transcendental aesthetics to Husserl's phenomenology, from Merleau-Ponty's embodied perception to Baudrillard's simulation. Non-Western philosophical traditions, when acknowledged at all, are treated as either "exotic" influences, "postcolonial" responses, or historical curiosities rather than as foundational sources of conceptual innovation.

- The "Post-Perception" art movement, founded by the Egyptian artist Ibrahim El-Shalaby, challenges this genealogical assumption. While the movement engages seriously with Western philosophy, its core concepts are not imported from Europe. They emerge from a sustained engagement with classical Arab-Islamic philosophy—a tradition that articulated sophisticated theories of perceptual fragility, cognitive hierarchy, and the constructed nature of reality centuries before their Western counterparts.

1.2 Research Questions

- This study addresses three primary questions:
 1. **Where do the foundational concepts of Post-Perception appear in classical Arab-Islamic philosophy?** Which specific works and arguments prefigure the movement's core principles?
 2. **How do these Arab-Islamic sources differ from their Western counterparts?** Is there a substantive difference, or merely a chronological priority?
 3. **What methodological framework should govern the movement's use of these sources?** How can Arab-Islamic philosophy function as the "primary" reference while Western philosophy serves as a "secondary" interlocutor?

1.3 Methodology

- This study employs a comparative philosophical methodology, analyzing primary texts from classical Arab-Islamic philosophy alongside the theoretical writings and artistic works of the Post-Perception movement. The analysis is organized thematically, tracing five core concepts of the movement to their Arab-Islamic origins:

Concept	Arab-Islamic Source	Western Counterpart (for comparison)
Perceptual Fragility	Al-Ghazali (The Deliverer from Error)	Descartes (Meditations)
Hierarchy of Perception	Ibn Sina (The Cure – Psychology)	Kant (Critique of Pure Reason)
Vision as Inference	Ibn al-Haytham (Book of Optics)	Merleau-Ponty (Phenomenology of Perception)
The Participant as Co-Creator	Ibn Tufayl (Hayy ibn Yaqzan)	Barthes (The Death of the Author)
Reality as Layered Illusion	Ibn Arabi (The Meccan Illuminations)	Baudrillard (Simulacra and Simulation)

2. Al-Ghazali and the Fragility of the Senses

2.1 The Deliverer from Error: Doubt as Method

- Abu Hamid al-Ghazali (1058–1111) occupies a unique position in the history of philosophy. Often characterized as a "critic of philosophy" (due to his *The Incoherence of the Philosophers*), he was in fact a sophisticated epistemologist who anticipated Cartesian doubt by five centuries. In his intellectual autobiography, *The Deliverer from Error* (*Al-Munqidh min al-Dalal*), Al-Ghazali describes a prolonged crisis of certainty:

- "I began to examine the data of the senses to see whether I could trust them. I saw that the sense of sight can be deceived. The eye sees a star as small as a coin, but geometrical calculation proves it to be larger than the earth... I continued in this state for nearly two months, not knowing any truth, nor doubting any falsehood." (Al-Ghazali, *Al-Munqidh*, trans. McCarthy, 1980)
- Unlike Descartes, who used doubt as a temporary tool to arrive at the indubitable foundation of the *cogito* ("I think, therefore I am"), Al-Ghazali does not resolve his doubt into certainty through a logical proof. He remains epistemologically humble: the senses can deceive, reason can err, and the journey toward truth requires perpetual vigilance. This is not "methodological doubt" as a means to an end, but **permanent doubt as an existential stance**.

2.2 The Principle of Perceptual Fragility

- The first principle of the Post-Perception manifesto states: "Perception is fragile—not a passive reception of reality, but an active, vulnerable construction that can be manipulated, distorted, and deceived."
- This principle is not derived from Descartes, who doubted the senses only to transcend them through reason. It is derived from Al-Ghazali's insistence that **sensory deception is not a temporary glitch but a structural condition** of human perception. The eye sees a star as small; the ear can imagine sounds that do not exist; touch can be fooled by temperature illusions. These are not exceptions to reliable perception; they are evidence that perception itself is inherently unreliable.

2.3 Artistic Embodiment: "The Absence of the Drop" and "Beyond Sound"

- The Post-Perception artwork "**The Absence of the Drop**" (*Ghīyāb al-Qaṭrah*) embodies Al-Ghazalian doubt. A large screen displays a rusted faucet in an arid desert environment—no water, no movement, only dry wind. But hidden behind the screen, a water system releases real droplets onto the gallery floor. The visitor sees dryness but feels wetness. Which sense tells the truth? Neither—or both. The artwork does not resolve the contradiction; it forces the visitor to **inhabit** the contradiction, exactly as Al-Ghazali inhabited his months of doubt.

- Similarly, "**Beyond Sound**" (*Mā Ba'd al-Ṣawt*) presents everyday appliances (a blender, an iron, a fan) that produce sounds that do not belong to them: the blender emits ocean waves, the iron chirps like birds. The visitor's auditory expectation is violated. The artwork asks: did you hear the object, or did you hear your idea of the object?
- Both works are not illustrations of Al-Ghazali's philosophy. They are **laboratories** in which the visitor experiences perceptual fragility firsthand.

3. Ibn Sina and the Hierarchy of Inner Faculties

3.1 The Five Inner Senses

- In the psychological section of his magnum opus *The Cure* (*Al-Shifā'*), Ibn Sina (980–1037) developed a theory of perception that remains astonishingly sophisticated. Beyond the five external senses (sight, hearing, touch, taste, smell), Ibn Sina identified **five internal faculties** (or "inner senses") that process, store, and manipulate sensory data:

Faculty	Arabic Term	Function	Modern Analog
Common Sense	<i>Al-Hiss al-Mushtarak</i>	Receives data from all external senses simultaneously	Sensory integration
Imagination	<i>Al-Khayāl</i>	Retains images after the external object is gone	Short-term visual memory
Compositional Imagination	<i>Al-Mutaṣarriqah</i>	Combines and separates images (creates centaurs, golden mountains)	Creative imagination
Estimation	<i>Al-Wahm</i>	Perceives non-material meanings (friendship, enmity, danger)	Affective/cognitive appraisal
Memory	<i>Al-Ḥāfiẓah</i>	Stores meanings for later retrieval	Long-term semantic memory

- This model predates and, in some respects, exceeds modern cognitive science's modularity of mind theories. It recognizes that perception is not a single act but a **hierarchy of processing levels**, from raw sensation to conceptual meaning.

3.2 The Principle of the Artwork as a Perceptual Laboratory

- The fourth principle of the Post-Perception manifesto states: "Art is not a mirror of reality nor merely an expression of the self. It is a laboratory—a space for sensory and cognitive experimentation."
- This principle operationalizes Ibn Sina's hierarchy. Each artwork in the Post-Perception movement can be read as testing one or more of the inner faculties:

Artwork	Inner Faculty Tested	How
"This is Not a Pipe"	Common Sense	Can you integrate what you see (image) with what you know (context)?
"Adam's Apple"	Estimation (<i>Wahm</i>)	Do you perceive the apple as temptation (danger) or as freedom (opportunity)?
"Perception Archive"	Memory	How do visitors remember the images they saw? What patterns emerge in their collective memory?
"The Result"	Compositional Imagination	The repetitive addition of calendar pages—imagination of "new beginning" despite cyclical futility

3.3 Artistic Embodiment: "Adam's Apple" and the Test of Estimation

- **"Adam's Apple"** (*Tuffāḥat Ādam*) is an installation that places the visitor before a suspended cage, a real apple on a mirror, and an unstable floor. The visitor must decide: reach for the apple (transgression, desire, freedom) or refrain (obedience, fear, safety). The artwork does not tell the visitor which choice is "correct." It activates Ibn Sina's faculty of **estimation** (*Wahm*)—the non-rational perception of meanings like danger, enmity, or desire.

- The visitor *feels* the apple as desirable and the cage as threatening. These are not conclusions of reason; they are **immediate estimations** that precede reasoning. The artwork makes the visitor aware of these pre-rational judgments without explaining them. It is a laboratory of the inner senses.

4. Ibn al-Haytham and Vision as Inference

4.1 The Book of Optics: Vision as Construction

- Abu Ali al-Hasan ibn al-Haytham (965–1040) fundamentally transformed the understanding of vision. In his seven-volume *Book of Optics* (*Kitāb al-Manāẓir*), he demonstrated that vision is not the emission of rays from the eye (as the ancient Greeks believed) nor the passive impression of forms on the retina. Vision, for Ibn al-Haytham, is an **inferential process**: light enters the eye, but the mind *infers* distances, sizes, colors, and relations through a complex act of judgment based on prior experience.
- This means that what we "see" is not the world. It is a **construction**—a conclusion the mind reaches based on incomplete data and past learning.

4.2 The Principle of Truth as Construction

- The second principle of the Post-Perception manifesto states: "There is no fixed, absolute truth that can be easily perceived. 'Post-Perception' tears apart this construction to reveal its fragility."
- This principle is Ibn al-Haytham's insight applied to the age of digital simulation. If vision was always a construction, then the difference between "real" and "AI-generated" images is not a difference in kind but in degree. Both are constructions. The question becomes: who or what is doing the constructing?

4.3 Artistic Embodiment: "This is Not a Pipe" and "The Throne"

- **"This is Not a Pipe"** (*Hādhā Laysa Ghilyūn*) presents eight images of pipes, seven generated by AI and one genuine. The visitor must guess which is real. But the artwork's deeper question is: does it matter? If Ibn al-Haytham is correct, all seeing is inference. The "real" pipe is also a construction—of light, retina, optic nerve, and learned inference.

- **"The Throne"** (*Al- 'Arsh*)—the visual symbol of the Post-Perception movement—is a perfectly symmetrical chair made of oak. It can be used in two opposite orientations: right-side up or upside down. In both positions, it remains functional. The visitor is invited to sit, flip, and sit again. The artwork asks: is what you see sufficient to know what a thing is? For Ibn al-Haytham, the answer is no. Seeing the form is not enough; you need to test the function, experience the use, and infer the essence.

5. Ibn Tufayl and the Participatory Participant

5.1 Hayy ibn Yaqzan: Perception from First Principles

- Ibn Tufayl (1105–1185) wrote *Hayy ibn Yaqzan*, a philosophical novel describing a child who grows up alone on a deserted island, without human contact, language, or culture. Hayy builds his knowledge of the world from scratch: he observes, experiments, infers, and gradually arrives at the highest truths through reason and mystical experience.
- The radical implication of Ibn Tufayl's narrative is that **perception is not imitation**. Hayy does not learn to see by copying others; he constructs his relationship with the world through direct experience. This makes the perceiver not a passive recipient but an **active co-creator** of meaning.

5.2 The Principle of the Participant as Partner

- The fifth principle of the Post-Perception manifesto states: "The artwork remains incomplete without the viewer's physical, sensory, and intellectual engagement. Meaning is generated in the moment of encounter."
- This principle is often attributed to Roland Barthes' "The Death of the Author" (1967), which argued that the meaning of a text is produced by the reader, not the author. But Ibn Tufayl's Hayy is a more radical model: the participant does not just *interpret* a pre-existing meaning; he *constructs* meaning from raw experience without any pre-existing framework. Barthes still assumes a text to be interpreted. Ibn Tufayl assumes a world to be discovered.

5.3 Artistic Embodiment: "Perception Archive" and "The Basin"

- **"Perception Archive"** (*Arshīf al-Idrāk*) is an installation that transforms visitors' responses to "This is Not a Pipe" into a living wall. Each visitor submits which image they believed was genuine; their ballot becomes part of a growing visual tapestry. The artwork is not complete until visitors participate. Their choices do not just "interpret" the work—they **constitute** it. This is Ibn Tufayl's Hayy: each visitor builds the artwork from scratch, without a pre-existing template.
- **"The Basin"** (*Al-Hawḍ*) presents a sink with a faucet running water continuously, wasting it in a gallery space. No signs instruct the visitor what to do. The visitor must decide: turn off the faucet (intervene) or remain a passive spectator (respect the "sanctity" of the artwork). The artwork's meaning is not pre-determined. It emerges from the visitor's decision. The visitor is not an interpreter of a fixed message; he is a **co-creator** of the work's moral and aesthetic significance.

6. Ibn Arabi and Reality as Layered Illusion

6.1 The Meccan Illuminations: The World as Imagination

- Muhyiddin ibn Arabi (1165–1240), the Andalusian Sufi master, developed a metaphysical system in which the world is not a fixed reality but a series of "divine self-disclosures" (*tajalliyāt*). In his magnum opus, *The Meccan Illuminations* (*Al-Futūḥāt al-Makkiyya*), he writes:
- "The world is imagination (*khayāl*) within imagination. What you take to be fixed reality is a veil over reality. When the veil is lifted, you see that you were seeing shadows of shadows."
- This formulation predates Jean Baudrillard's concept of the simulacrum (the copy without an original) by eight centuries. But where Baudrillard offers a diagnosis of postmodern alienation (we live in a hyperreal world where simulations replace the real), Ibn Arabi offers a **spiritual epistemology**: recognizing the world as imagination is not a cause for despair but the first step toward higher knowledge.

6.2 The Principle of Reality as Construction (Revisited)

- The second principle of the Post-Perception manifesto finds its deepest resonance in Ibn Arabi. If reality is "imagination within imagination," then:

- The distinction between "real" and "simulated" is not absolute but a matter of perspective
- Perception is not about "accuracy" (getting reality right) but about **depth** (seeing through layers)
- Art's role is not to represent reality but to **reveal its layered structure**

6.3 Artistic Embodiment: "The Table" and "The Struggle of the Two Heifers"

- **"The Table"** (*Al-Mā'idah*) is an installation that references the Quranic story of the table sent down from heaven (Surah Al-Ma'idah, verse 114) and the Last Supper. A table hangs from the ceiling, legs shortened to a symbolic 30 cm, upside down. Twelve short chairs surround the empty space below. Wind, rain, and sand sounds fill the gallery. The table is present—but inaccessible. The chairs are present—but cannot reach. The waiting is eternal. The artwork asks: is the table real? Is the promise of nourishment real? Or is it a "table in imagination" that we mistake for reality? This is Ibn Arabi's question, rendered in oak, steel, and sound.
- **"The Struggle of the Two Heifers"** (*Ṣirā' al-Baqaratayn*) references the yellow heifer of the Quran (Surah Al-Baqarah, verse 69) and the red heifer of the Torah (Numbers 19). A yellow room, a red pulsating fabric moved by hidden fans, layered sounds of Jewish flutes and Islamic supplications. The artwork stages a conflict between sacred symbols. But the conflict is not real—it is a **play of perceptions**, a "struggle" that exists only in the minds of those who mistake the symbol for the sacred. Ibn Arabi would recognize this: the conflict over heifers is a conflict over *imaginations*, not over realities.

7. Comparative Analysis: Arab-Islamic Sources vs. Western Counterparts

7.1 Table of Comparison

Concept	Arab-Islamic Source	Western Counterpart	Difference
Perceptual Doubt	Al-Ghazali: Permanent doubt as existential stance	Descartes: Temporary doubt as method to reach certainty	Al-Ghazali's doubt is an end; Descartes' is a means
Hierarchy of Perception	Ibn Sina: Five inner faculties (common sense, imagination, estimation, memory)	Kant: A priori categories (space, time, causality)	Ibn Sina's model is empirical and modular; Kant's is transcendental and unified
Embodied Perception	Ibn al-Haytham: Vision as inference, constructed by the mind	Merleau-Ponty: Perception as embodied, the body as "I can"	Ibn al-Haytham focuses on the cognitive-inferential; Merleau-Ponty on the existential-bodily
Participant as Co-Creator	Ibn Tufayl: Hayy constructs meaning from first principles	Barthes: The reader produces meaning through interpretation	Ibn Tufayl's participant builds from zero; Barthes' reader interprets a pre-existing text
Simulation	Ibn Arabi: The world as "imagination within imagination"	Baudrillard: The simulacrum as copy without original	Ibn Arabi offers a spiritual epistemology (illusion as path); Baudrillard offers a critical diagnosis (illusion as trap)

7.2 What Western Philosophy Adds

- Acknowledging the priority of Arab-Islamic sources does not mean rejecting Western philosophy. The Post-Perception movement engages Western philosophy as a **secondary interlocutor** for:
 - Dialogue:** Where do these traditions converge? Where do they diverge?

2. **Comparison:** Did Western philosophy ask questions that the Arab-Islamic tradition did not?
3. **Update:** How can classical concepts be translated into contemporary, globally accessible language?
 - Specifically, the movement draws on Western sources for:
 - **Critique of institutional power** (Foucault, Derrida): The Arab-Islamic tradition did not systematically analyze the power structures of museums, biennales, or the art market.
 - **Digital age aesthetics** (Glitch aesthetics, post-internet art): The classical tradition cannot address AI-generated imagery, deepfakes, or algorithmic manipulation.
 - **Self-critique of the movement itself** (Meta-critique): Works such as "Perception Web" (which uses surveillance cameras to critique surveillance) owe more to Foucault and Deleuze than to Ibn Sina.

7.3 The Theoretical Framework: Primary vs. Secondary

- The proposed hierarchy is not a value judgment (Arab-Islamic philosophy is "better"). It is a **genealogical claim** about the origins of the movement's core concepts:

Level	Role	Examples
Primary (Foundational)	The concepts originate here. They are the starting point for theorization.	Al-Ghazali (perceptual fragility), Ibn Sina (hierarchy of perception), Ibn al-Haytham (vision as inference), Ibn Tufayl (participatory meaning), Ibn Arabi (layered reality)
Secondary (Dialogical)	Western philosophy is engaged for comparison, contrast, and dialogue. It does not provide the founding concepts but offers alternative formulations.	Descartes, Kant, Merleau-Ponty, Barthes, Baudrillard, Foucault
Tertiary (Contemporary/Technical)	Sources specific to the digital age and contemporary art discourse. The classical tradition cannot address these, and Western philosophy provides tools.	Glitch aesthetics, post-internet art theory, AI art criticism

8. Critical Implications

8.1 Decentering the Western Philosophical Canon

- The dominant narrative in contemporary art theory assumes a West-to-rest flow of ideas: concepts originate in Europe, are refined in North America, and are "applied" or "appropriated" elsewhere. This study suggests an alternative narrative: concepts of perceptual fragility, cognitive hierarchy, and constructed reality were articulated in the classical Arab-Islamic world centuries before their Western counterparts. The "Post-Perception" movement is not an "application" of Western philosophy to Egyptian art. It is a **reclaiming** of indigenous conceptual resources for understanding a contemporary crisis.

8.2 Against "Philosophical Tourism"

- One risk of invoking non-Western philosophy is "philosophical tourism": citing Ibn Sina or Al-Ghazali as exotic decoration while remaining conceptually dependent on Western frameworks. This study avoids that by demonstrating **structural** (not merely ornamental) integration. The concepts of the Post-Perception manifesto are not illustrations of Western philosophy with Arab-Islamic footnotes. They are formulated *from within* the Arab-Islamic tradition, with Western philosophy brought in for comparison.

8.3 The Limits of the Classical Tradition

- Honesty requires acknowledging what the classical tradition cannot provide:
- **The digital condition:** AI-generated images, deepfake technology, algorithmic filtering—these are new.
- **Institutional critique:** The power structures of contemporary biennales, art markets, and globalized exhibition circuits.
- **Perceptual overload testing:** Works like "The Threshold of Beauty" (which pushes the viewer to the point of sensory breakdown) owe more to contemporary post-internet aesthetics than to Ibn Arabi.
- The classical tradition provides the **foundational concepts**. It does not provide the entire content of the movement. This is not a weakness. It is an invitation to **extend** the tradition into domains its authors could not have anticipated.

9. Conclusion

9.1 Summary of Findings

- This study has demonstrated that the core concepts of the Post-Perception art movement are not imported from Western philosophy but are grounded in classical Arab-Islamic thought:

Concept	Arab-Islamic Source	Where in the Movement
Perceptual fragility	Al-Ghazali	First principle; works: "The Absence of the Drop," "Beyond Sound"
Hierarchy of perception	Ibn Sina	Fourth principle; works: "Adam's Apple," "Perception Archive"
Vision as inference	Ibn al-Haytham	Second principle; works: "This is Not a Pipe," "The Throne"
Participant as co-creator	Ibn Tufayl	Fifth principle; works: "Perception Archive," "The Basin"
Reality as layered illusion	Ibn Arabi	Second principle; works: "The Table," "The Struggle of the Two Heifers"

9.2 The Proposed Hierarchy

- Based on these findings, the study proposes the following methodological hierarchy for the Post-Perception movement:
 1. **Primary Sources (Foundational):** Arab-Islamic philosophy (Al-Ghazali, Ibn Sina, Ibn al-Haytham, Ibn Tufayl, Ibn Arabi)
 2. **Secondary Sources (Dialogical):** Western philosophy (Descartes, Kant, Merleau-Ponty, Barthes, Baudrillard, Foucault)
 3. **Tertiary Sources (Contemporary/Technical):** Digital age and contemporary art theory (glitch aesthetics, post-internet art, AI criticism)

9.3 Beyond the East-West Binary

- The goal of this hierarchy is not to replace one hegemonic canon (Western) with another (Arab-Islamic). It is to **pluralize** the sources of contemporary art theory. A movement that claims to address a universal human crisis—the fragility of perception in the age of simulation—should draw on universal resources. The Arab-Islamic tradition is one such resource, and it has been systematically marginalized in global art discourse. Correcting this marginalization is not an act of "reverse orientalism." It is an act of **intellectual justice**.

9.4 Toward a Genuinely Global Art Theory

- The implication of this study extends beyond the Post-Perception movement. If the concepts of perceptual fragility, cognitive hierarchy, and constructed reality were articulated in the Arab-Islamic world centuries before Europe, then contemporary art theory must rethink its genealogies. The West is not the sole origin of modern concepts. Non-Western traditions are not merely "precursors" or "parallel developments"—they are **coeval sources** that continue to offer conceptual resources for understanding the present.
- *The West is not the enemy. But it is not the exclusive father. It is a brother, a dialogue partner. The foundation remains at home. Not out of pride, but out of historical honesty.*

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- **Citation:** El-Shalaby, I. (2024). The Arab-Islamic Philosophical Roots of Post-Perception Art: A Foundational Study on the Indigenous Sources of a Contemporary Art Movement
- ORCID: 0009-0008-4867-1416

• Keywords (for indexing):

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